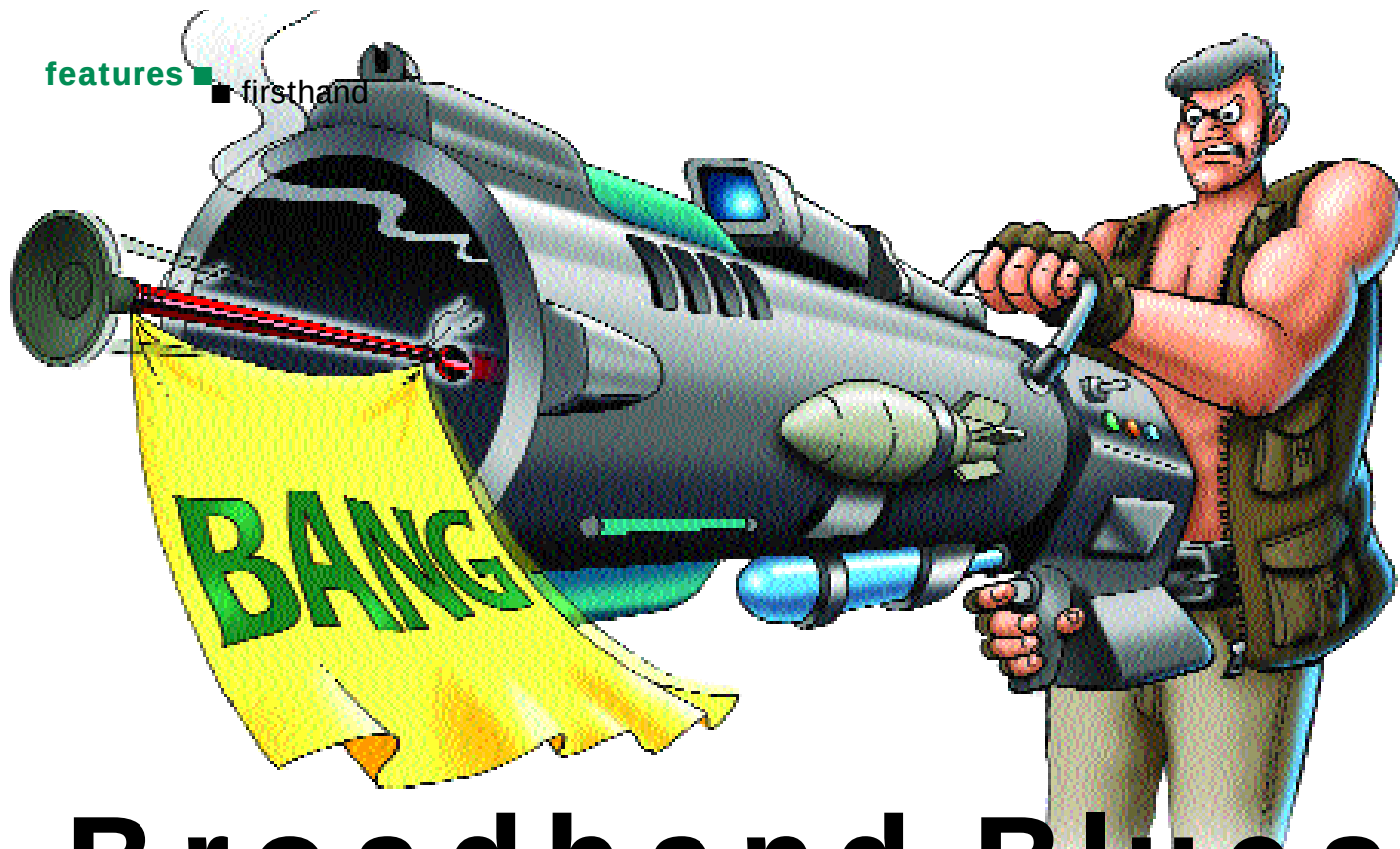




Broadband Blues

Dreams of high-speed Internet access wither in the face of reality

“ *You promised me heaven,
then put me through hell* **”**
—JON BON JOVI

The sentiment reflected in these words has touched our collective soul at one point or another. The reasons for crooning those lyrics can be many: Bon Jovi obviously had an unhappy tryst with a heartbreaker, a situation that might seem painfully familiar to most of us; while others find themselves humming the line as they surf the Internet. Shattered hearts or pulled out hair, the source of the pain remains the same: promises broken, potential unrealised.

While we would love to delve into the world of romance and poetry, let's stick to the subject at hand. Broadband has become a household name, synonymous with high-speed Internet access and one that conjures visions of streaming movies while video-conferencing with your aunt in England, even as you download the latest songs. Unfortunately, like most visions, this one too goes up in smoke when scorched by the unforgiving flames of reality. So what is this 'broadband' thing anyway, and do we, as a higher species really need it?

Let's get a little technical. Broadband refers to any type of transmission technique that carries several data channels over a common wire. A DSL (Digital Subscriber Line) service, for example, combines separate voice and data channels over a single telephone line—voice fills the low end of the frequency spectrum and data (which can in turn be audio, video and text) fills the high end. While this might seem like a nice thing to do to a wire, what really excites is the speed that such a connection can deliver. Consider Cable technology: it can theoretically achieve net-

working speeds of approximately 30 Mbps; now compare it to the measly 56 Kbps that the best dial-up connection can offer and the contrast seems bewildering; even a DSL line can touch speeds of up to 10 Mbps. A broadband connection is thus a good thing, like a hefty bank balance; but as we will soon find out the analogy goes further—for much like a burgeoning wallet, a speedy Internet connection is also reduced to being just a pipe dream for the most of us.

Fight the system

Our story begins with a broadband service that should theoretically deliver the most bang for the buck, Internet over optic fibres. Like all sad tales, this one begins with a little flashback: A 'last-mile connection' refers to the means by which a service provider delivers Internet to your home. Most providers rely on existing infrastructure and thus the last-mile consists of wires that belong to institutes such as BSNL and MTNL. Some providers, though, such as BSES TeleCom Ltd (BTL) rely on their own cabling, thanks largely to the nature of the solution they offer. BTL thus delivers a last-mile as a combination of fibre and Cat-5 cable: optic fibres deliver the Internet to a hub near you (typically a power terminal), from where cables emanate and transport packets of data to your home. BTL's broadband service, termed Powersurfer, thus seems to be the best of the bunch at first glance; it uses optic fibres after all. Practically though, the service has been marred by long installation periods and slow access speeds.

Take the case of Rafique Ilani, a Mumbai resident. He signed up for Powersurfer by making a down payment of Rs 3,500 as installation charges and was promised a connection within a month. Since BTL had to lay the optic cabling required, they needed permission from both MTNL and the Municipal Council